

Outly

User guide — Windows desktop application

Version 1.0.0 · 2026-11-08

Outly user guide

This guide covers the complete Windows application, from first launch to a repeatable weekly research routine. The repository documentation is English; the v1.0 interface is French. French labels are shown in **bold** with an English explanation.

1. What Outly is for

Outly answers four questions:

1. Which channels are genuinely close to my niche?
2. Which of their videos beat their own normal performance?
3. What should I make next, and why?
4. What did the last run cost in YouTube quota?

It is a local research tool, not an automation bot. It does not upload videos, post comments, subscribe, or manipulate a YouTube account. It reads public data through the official API and, only with your consent, private Studio analytics for your own channel.

2. Before the first run

2.1 Install

Use `release/Outly.exe` in its own writable folder, or follow INSTALL.md to run from source. Do not put the app in a protected folder such as `Program Files`; if the folder is read-only, Outly falls back to `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Outly`.

2.2 Create the starter files

On first launch the app creates:

- `config.yaml` — budgets, filters, output, email;
- `positioning.md` — who you serve and what makes your channel different;
- `seeds.txt` — competitors you already know;
- `keywords.txt` — phrases your audience searches;
- `.env` — API keys (initially empty placeholders).

`python -m outly init` does the same from a terminal and never overwrites an existing file.

2.3 Add the minimum keys

Open **Réglages -> Clés & modèle** (**Settings -> Keys & model**) or edit `.env`:

```
YOUTUBE_API_KEY=...
LLM_BASE_URL=https://generativelanguage.googleapis.com/v1beta/openai/
LLM_MODEL=gemini-3.5-flash-lite
LLM_API_KEY=...
```

Use `python -m outly doctor --offline` for a local check. Use `python -m outly doctor --probe` for one real YouTube call and a model listing. The probe consumes a small amount of quota; the offline check does not.

2.4 Describe your positioning

`positioning.md` is sent to the LLM for every channel. A useful file names:

- the viewer, their level, and their problem;
- your promise and tone;
- formats and usual lengths;
- what you do differently;
- adjacent topics and topics you refuse;
- competitors you never want to see.

Vague positioning produces vague scores. This is the highest-leverage file in the project.

2.5 Add seeds and keywords

`seeds.txt` accepts `@handle`, a full `@handle` URL, `/channel/UC...`, a raw `UC...` ID, or `/user/old-name`. Custom `/c/...` URLs are not resolvable by the API; convert them first.

`keywords.txt` contains one search expression per line. Ten to twenty good phrases are enough. Each line costs one `search.list` call; the international pass doubles that.

3. The interface at a glance

The left navigation has four groups:

French group	English meaning
Pilotage	Steering
Analyse	Analysis
Bibliothèque	Library
Configuration	Settings

Pages that belong together share tabs. The app remembers the last tab and the last page when configured to do so.

French page	English name	Main job
Accueil	Home	Readiness, quota, run, Studio summary

French page	English name	Main job
Audit	Audit	Full channel diagnosis and 30-day strategy
Stratégie	Strategy	Diagnose recent videos and plan tests
Studio YouTube	YouTube Studio	Long videos, Shorts, other content, competitors
Plan éditorial	Editorial plan	Upcoming videos, stages, tasks, production estimates
Schémas vidéo	Video schematics	Shot list, framing, text placement, timeline
Chaînes	Channels	Sortable candidate table and detail panel
Comparateur	Comparison	Two or three channels side by side
À regarder	Watchlist	Local saved videos and channels
Notes	Notes	Personal library with versions and ratings
Tableau blanc	Whiteboard	Infinite canvas with shapes and freehand drawing
Recherche	Research	Wikipedia-only or Wikipedia + Exa brief
Idées	Ideas	Video concepts with three distinct titles
Hooks	Hooks	Opening variants based on outlier intros
Cerveau IA	AI brain	Connect notes, research, ideas, and outliers
Mon contenu	My content	Edit positioning, seeds, keywords, my channel
Clés & modèle	Keys & model	Provider selection and live test
Réglages	Settings	Appearance, budgets, filters, LLM rate
Rapports e-mail	Email reports	Recipient, frequency, test, Windows task
Lancer	Launch	Options, estimate, live log, quota delta

The header has an **Organiser** (**Arrange**) control on pages with cards. Use the arrows to reorder blocks and the horizontal arrow to move a block between two columns. **Réinitialiser cette page** restores the original layout. These preferences are local and do not change research data.

4. Page-by-page guide

4.1 Accueil / Home

The home page is the pre-flight checklist. It shows whether the configuration, keys, positioning, seeds, and keywords are ready; the two quota gauges; a summary of the last Studio refresh; and a **Lancer** button for a full run. If a required file is missing, fix it here before launching. The run estimate is a range, not a guarantee: cache hits and API errors change the cost.

4.2 Mon contenu / My content

Edit `positioning.md`, `seeds.txt`, and `keywords.txt` without leaving the app. The **Ma chaîne** field writes `moi.chaine`; the international toggle writes `moi.recherche_internationale`. The page can import Markdown, text, JSON, HTML, OpenDocument, and PDF. Extracted text is previewed and only

written on **Ctrl+S**. Short bullet lines become seeds or keywords; a paragraph is never turned into a keyword. Scanned, password-protected, or textless PDFs are rejected with a clear explanation. Position text sent to the LLM is capped, but the file keeps the full text.

4.3 Clés & modèle / Keys & model

Select Gemini, Groq, Mistral, Ollama Cloud, or Ollama local. The provider selector pre-fills the base URL and a model name. Keys are masked. **Tester** makes a real call, so it costs a small amount of quota/credit. The fallback LLM is optional. API keys never appear in reports or logs.

4.4 Réglages / Settings

Apparence & confort controls theme, table text size, shadows, delete confirmation, and whether to reopen the last page. Preferences live in `data/preferences.json`. The rest of the page edits budgets, subscriber/age filters, Shorts cutoff, LLM rate, cache TTL, output format, and email schedule; comments in `config.yaml` are preserved. Invalid combinations (minimum subscribers above maximum, run budget above daily budget) are refused before a write.

4.5 Lancer / Launch

Choose optional outlier analysis and transcript reading, review the estimated duration, then start. The log streams in real time. Buttons are disabled while a task runs; the app records the quota delta at the end. A clean quota stop is not a crash: the report may be partial. You can close the window, but a running child process may continue briefly; reopen and inspect the log rather than starting a second run immediately.

4.6 Chaînes / Channels

The table shows retained channels in bold with a filled marker and rejected channels with an open marker. Filter **Toutes / Retenues / Écartées** (All / Retained / Rejected), sort by any column, and select a row for details: description, score, audience, cadence, medians, best outliers, thumbnails, and links. The detail panel can save a channel to the watchlist. Rejected channels keep the reason they were rejected; this is deliberate, so the result can be audited rather than treated as magic.

4.7 Comparateur / Comparison

Compare two or three channels side by side: score, audience, medians, cadence, formats, language, best outlier, and a local **follow priority** score from 0 to 100. The priority card explains its weights: proximity 35%, outlier 25%, cadence 15%, freshness 10%, audience 15%. It is a local heuristic, not an LLM answer, and it makes no network call.

4.8 Studio YouTube

Four tabs:

- **Vidéos longues** (long videos): views, watch time, impressions, CTR, retention, daily views, traffic sources, devices, age, and gender;
- **Shorts**: the same view, limited to videos of 180 seconds or less;
- **Autres contenus** (other content): lives and replays detected through `liveStreamingDetails`, plus an explicit explanation of API limits for posts, polls, and questionnaires;

- **Concurrents** (competitors): choose a channel found by discovery and see cumulative views by publication date, known videos, total announced views, coverage, and one card per video.

The competitor curve is reconstructed from **current** view counts. It is not a daily history; YouTube only provides daily history for your own channel. The **Ma chaîne YouTube** block is hidden in the competitor tab. Private metrics require OAuth from the channel owner. Follow the four-step guide on the page and `guides/youtube-studio.md`. Analytics can lag 24-48 hours, and Google may refuse impressions; the page explains missing data rather than inventing it.

4.9 Audit

The audit combines your channel's measured profile, the ten closest competitors, notes, keywords, seeds, watchlist, positioning, and the last AI brain analysis. It produces:

1. the real sector and sub-niche;
2. strengths, weaknesses, and opportunities, each tied to a measurement;
3. competitor mechanics, examples, why they work, and gaps to exploit;
4. a content strategy: positioning, promise, 3-5 pillars, formats, cadence, series, a 30-day plan, and 4-6 KPIs;
5. ten video ideas with a publishable title, angle, reason, and format;
6. the limits of what the data can support.

With a YouTube key, the audit first refreshes your own channel. It never moves your channel into the competitor pool. `--sans-recuperation` skips the refresh. An identical audit is cached; `--force` regenerates it.

4.10 Stratégie / Strategy

The strategy page diagnoses recent videos from the Studio cache, or from public videos when Studio is unavailable. Local rules flag views below the median, low CTR, low retention, early drop-off, and long titles. With an LLM, each finding gets plausible causes and a test. Voice and editing are not measured by YouTube Analytics, so they remain labeled as hypotheses. The result is cached by fingerprint.

4.11 Plan éditorial / Editorial plan

Create upcoming videos with title, planned date, stage (idea, script, shoot, edit, published), format, and notes. Overdue and near dates are highlighted. Each card has its own checklist; tasks can be added, counted, and removed. **Estimer la production** estimates time per phase, gear with quantities, footage, budget, and a checklist. Without an LLM, a local estimate by format is used and labeled as such.

4.12 Schémas vidéo / Video schematics

Build the structure of a Short or a long video: shot type, framing, face-camera presence, text placement, a reorderable timeline, and a checklist. It is a local planning surface, not a renderer.

4.13 Hooks

Hooks read timestamped transcripts of outlier videos, ask the LLM where the intro starts and ends, and write opening variants for a chosen subject. Each variant names the technique and the source outlier.

Without transcripts the command stops rather than inventing quotes. Active notes can influence the variants. **Noter** saves a variant as a note. `--force` regenerates; intro analyses are reused.

4.14 Cerveau IA / AI brain

The AI brain reads active notes, research briefs, generated ideas, the editorial plan, the watchlist, positioning, hooks, and recent outliers. It returns a synthesis, angles, possible titles, questions, and non-obvious connections, plus a 3D map of related points. Higher-rated notes and watchlist items are treated as stronger context. Archived notes are excluded by default. The page shows the material it read, so the input is visible rather than assumed. Research facts marked "to verify" are never presented as established.

4.15 Idées / Ideas

Ideas use rated notes, positioning, keywords and seeds, competitor keywords, best outliers, watchlist items, and the last AI brain result. Each idea includes a sourced reason and exactly three titles with different angles: demonstration, counter-intuition, investigation, mistake to avoid, guide, or story. Two titles that reformulate the same promise do not count. From the UI a title can be copied or sent to the editorial plan; **Créer une note** keeps the whole idea.

4.16 Recherche / Research

Enter a title and keywords. **Sans IA** (No AI) queries the MediaWiki API only; it needs no LLM or Exa key. **Avec IA** (With AI) asks the LLM for viewer intent and verification queries, reads Wikipedia, queries Exa, and builds a sourced brief. A claim is marked **recoupé** (cross-checked) only when at least three independent recognized web domains support it. Wikipedia is a starting point and does not count as one of the three. Below that threshold, the claim is marked **à vérifier** (to verify). Unsupported claims are removed; disagreements are preserved. Identical briefs are cached; `--force` regenerates.

4.17 Tableau blanc / Whiteboard

An infinite local canvas with pen, sticky notes, text, arrows, twelve colors, a pointer eraser that actually cuts strokes, and ten geometric shapes in addition to rectangle and ellipse. Undo and redo use **Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Y**. Right-click zooms and pans. The board saves locally to `data/tableau-blanc.json`; keep a copy before experimenting with a large board.

4.18 Notes

Notes have a title, body, type (hook, concept, topic, idea, reference, note), status (draft, to test, validated, archived), tags, source, pin, and a rating from 0 to 10 or "not rated". Search covers title, body, tags, and source. Saving happens after a typing pause; content changes create restorable versions in **Historique** (History). Ratings drive the priority of context sent to the AI brain. Archived notes are excluded by default.

4.19 À regarder / Watchlist

A local playlist of saved videos and channels with a rating, a browser link, and a remove action. It feeds the AI brain and ideas. It is not a YouTube playlist; nothing is written to your YouTube account.

5. A reliable weekly routine

1. **Monday:** update seeds and keywords with what you learned last week.
2. Run discovery with a modest search budget. Check the dry-run estimate first.
3. Enrich and score. Read the rejected reasons before trusting the top ten.
4. Compare two or three close channels. Save useful videos to the watchlist.
5. Run **Audit** only when positioning or the competitive set changed.
6. Turn one or two ideas into editorial-plan cards with dates and tasks.
7. Write hooks for the next video; save the best one as a note.
8. After publishing, refresh Studio and run **Strategy**.

Avoid rerunning everything because a button exists. Cache hits are cheap, but LLM calls and analysis still take time.

6. Quota and reports

`python -m outly quota` shows two counters for the current Pacific day. A run stops cleanly at the configured budget; exit code 3 means partial data, not a crash. `out/channels.csv`, `out/outliers.csv`, and `out/report.md` are written atomically. CSV uses `;` and a UTF-8 BOM by default for French Excel. Change `output.csv_separator` for `,` and keep the encoding if you need accents.

Email reports are optional. The sender is fixed by the app; only the recipient and schedule are configurable. Create a Gmail app password, put it in `.env` as `SMTP_PASSWORD`, and use **Envoyer un test** (Send a test) before scheduling. The Windows task wakes daily and `mail --si-du` decides whether the chosen frequency is due. A missed slot is caught up once, not once per missed day. No empty report is sent. Attachments have size caps and the body says when one was omitted.

7. Backup, update, and recovery

Back up with SQLite's backup API while the app is closed or between runs:

```
import sqlite3
from pathlib import Path

source = Path("data/radar.sqlite3")
target = Path("backup/radar-copy.sqlite3")
target.parent.mkdir(parents=True, exist_ok=True)
with sqlite3.connect(source) as src, sqlite3.connect(target) as dst:
    src.backup(dst)
```

Then open the copy and run `PRAGMA quick_check`; it should return `ok`. A plain file copy during a write can be inconsistent. To restore, close Outly, keep the current database under a dated name, put the verified backup in place, and run `doctor --offline`.

To update, keep `config.yaml`, `.env`, `positioning.md`, `seeds.txt`, `keywords.txt`, and `data/`; replace only the application files. Database migrations are additive, but a backup before a major version is still wise.

8. Label glossary

French	English
Retenues / Écartées	Retained / Rejected
Toutes	All
Ma chaîne	My channel
Recherche internationale	International search
Clés & modèle	Keys & model
Apparence & confort	Appearance & comfort
Enregistrer	Save
Tester	Test
Lancer	Launch
Durée estimée	Estimated duration
Journal	Log
Quota du jour	Today's quota
Actualiser	Refresh
Connecter ma chaîne	Connect my channel
Envoyer un test	Send a test
Programmer sur ce PC	Schedule on this PC
À vérifier	To verify
Recoupé	Cross-checked
Sans IA / Avec IA	No AI / With AI

9. Limits you should know

- YouTube has no supported similar-channel endpoint; discovery is heuristic.
- `search.list` produces noise; the score is a filter, not truth.
- Transcript reading uses an unofficial interface and may fail or be blocked.
- Public view counts are current totals, not daily history.
- Cached API data expires within 30 days.
- The executable is unsigned.
- The v1.0 UI is French; this guide translates the workflow.
- The GUI has limited automated coverage; always keep a database backup.

For failures and recovery, see TROUBLESHOOTING.md. For every command and option, see CLI_REFERENCE.md.